



National Drug and Health Products Authority Bill, 2025

What the Bill changes, and why it matters for the executive team

Broader Scope

The Bill replaces and expands Uganda's current drug-focused regime with a broader framework covering drugs, medical devices, certain cosmetics, public health products, and nutritional supplements.

Stronger Enforcement

It strengthens the Authority's enforcement toolkit, especially around licensing, inspections, recall, lot release, and site intervention.

Executive Impact

For the executive team, the main issue is practical impact: where the business will face new regulatory obligations, higher compliance costs, and greater operational disruption risk.

Organised by Function

This deck is organised by function so each team can see its highest-priority issues clearly.

How to Read the RAG Ratings

We are judging practical impact, not just whether wording in the law is new

Red

Genuinely new or materially expanded, with meaningful cost, process, market-access, or disruption implications. Requires immediate executive attention and resource allocation.

Yellow

Requires change, but is generally manageable and often aligns with existing good practice. Plan and resource accordingly.

Green

Mainly codifies what large ethical operators already do, usually increasing pressure on weaker market participants.

 In this Bill, the biggest **Red** themes are expanded product scope, stronger intervention powers, formal recall and lot release tools, and tighter control of distribution and pharmacy operations.



Executive Summary

What matters most across the company



Broader Product Scope

The Bill increases the number of product categories that may need formal regulatory ownership and approval.



Operational Interruption Risk

It raises the risk of operational interruption through stronger inspections, stop actions, recalls, and market withdrawals.



Execution Pressure

Higher execution pressure on registration, distribution control, traceability, release, and pharmacy-channel governance.



One Compliance Model

The strongest businesses will be those that can operate one disciplined compliance model across the full portfolio.

Corporate Leadership and Governance

The Bill becomes a strategic governance issue, not just a regulatory affairs issue

⚠️ RED – HIGH PRIORITY

Broadened Regulated Perimeter

The regulated perimeter broadens materially, which can change portfolio economics, risk appetite, and operating model choices.

Executive-Level Incidents

Stronger inspector powers, recall tools, and site-intervention powers increase the likelihood that quality failures become executive-level incidents.

Director Due Diligence

Directors and managers face a clearer expectation to show due diligence if the business is found non-compliant.

COST IMPLICATIONS

- 1 **Central programme management**
- 2 **Legal and advisory support**
- 3 **Governance and escalation redesign**
- 4 **More executive time on regulatory risk oversight**

📄 Yellow: broader reporting, records, and certification obligations will need disciplined coordination. Green: many baseline quality and integrity expectations are already standard in ethical companies.

Regulatory Affairs and Market Authorisation

This team will carry much of the immediate implementation burden

 RED – HIGH PRIORITY

New Product Class Registration

New product classes may require registration, notification, or listing where previously they sat outside the core drug regime.

Formal Approvals Dependency

Market access becomes more dependent on formal approvals across manufacture, import, export, and distribution.

Recall and Stop-Supply Powers

Recall, withdrawal, and Authority stop-supply powers increase the regulatory consequences of dossier gaps or product non-conformity.

 Executive implication: this function may need broader portfolio coverage, stronger submission planning, and tighter lifecycle control.

COST IMPLICATIONS

- More submissions and renewals
- Dossier remediation
- Regulatory headcount or external support
- System upgrades for approval tracking and change control

 Yellow: packaging, labelling, and advertising controls will need closer product-by-product review. Green: for mature medicines portfolios, core registration discipline is already familiar.

R&D, Clinical, and Medical

Expansion beyond traditional drug regulation matters here

Scope Expansion

Clinical trial and field-trial control extends more clearly across **devices, cosmetics, nutritional supplements, and public health products** – not only traditional medicines.

Lot release for vaccines, biologicals, and diagnostics adds an additional release and evidence burden for relevant categories.

 Executive implication: development plans and evidence-generation strategies may need to adjust for a broader and more formal regulatory gate.

COST IMPLICATIONS

- **Added protocol and submission work**
- **More regulator engagement during studies**
- **Possible delays in study timelines or product release**
- **Increased medical and safety oversight requirements**

 Yellow: GCP-style expectations and safety surveillance will become more explicit and inspectable. Green: established drug-development teams will recognise much of the underlying discipline already.

Manufacturing and Technical Operations

The Bill increases both licensing intensity and interruption risk at site level

● Expanded Licensing Scope

More sites and product lines may need to operate under formal manufacturing licences and regulated oversight.

● Stronger Inspection Powers

Including seizure and sealing-off of premises, raising the operational stakes of site non-compliance significantly.

● Lot Release Requirements

Lot release requirements matter directly for vaccine, biologic, and diagnostic operations.

⊗ Executive implication: manufacturing readiness becomes a **business continuity issue**, not just a plant-compliance issue.

⚠ Yellow: GMP certification and quality-system expectations are broadened and reinforced.

✓ Green: large ethical plants should already have the foundations, but the legal and operational consequences now become sharper.

COST IMPLICATIONS

- Site remediation and upgrade spend
- Licence and inspection readiness work
- Release delays and working-capital impact
- Higher disruption cost if a site issue triggers regulator action

Quality Assurance, Quality Control, and Surveillance

QA becomes even more central to protecting continuity of supply

 RED – CRITICAL EXPOSURES

Recall and Destruction Powers

Explicit recall, withdrawal, and destruction powers mean quality failures can move faster into formal regulatory action.

External Testing and Enforcement

The Authority's laboratory and stronger evidence powers make external testing and enforcement more operationally significant.

Site-Level Intervention

The power to intervene at site level raises the cost of weak deviation management, CAPA, and inspection readiness.

 Executive implication: QA will sit at the centre of both **risk prevention** and **crisis response**.

COST IMPLICATIONS

- Stronger recall and crisis-management capability
- More testing, investigations, and documentation
- CAPA uplift and inspection-preparation effort
- Increased write-off risk from field actions

 Yellow: monitoring systems, traceability, and supply records will require more disciplined execution. Green: anti-falsification and substandard-product controls are already part of good practice.

Pharmacovigilance, Vigilance, and Post-Market Surveillance

Broader product vigilance becomes a bigger enterprise capability

● Red — Scope Expansion

Post-market monitoring and adverse-event or defect reporting extend **beyond drugs** into devices and other newly regulated products.

❗ Executive implication: the company may need to treat vigilance as a **wider portfolio capability**, not a drug-only process.

Cost Implications

- Broader intake and triage systems
- New SOPs and training for non-drug portfolios
- More coordination with distributors, providers, and customer-facing teams

● Yellow: Formal PV Systems

Formal pharmacovigilance systems for drugs, and monitoring systems for regulated products, become more explicit and inspectable.

● Yellow: Further Safety Follow-Up

The Authority may require studies or further safety follow-up as part of post-market obligations.

● Green: Established PV Discipline

Established ethical drug businesses often already operate most of the core PV discipline — the extension is to new product classes.

Supply Chain, Import, Export, and Logistics

Border control and traceability pressures rise materially

● Border Delay and Refusal Risk

New approvals and controls across a wider set of product classes increase the risk of border delay, refusal of entry, re-export, or destruction.

● Approved Ports and Routing

Approved ports of entry and exit, plus inspection powers, create more operational dependency on compliant routing and documentation.

● Reverse Logistics Capability

Recall and withdrawal powers increase the need for fast reverse-logistics capability across the supply network.

⊗ Executive implication: logistics resilience and import governance become more important to **continuity and working capital**.

COST IMPLICATIONS

- Customs and clearance friction
- Rework, re-export, or destruction costs
- Stock-holding increases to buffer delays
- More robust reverse logistics for field actions

📄 Yellow: storage and distribution practice requirements become more explicit and enforceable. Green: formal import discipline is already normal for top-tier operators, but the consequences of failure now rise.



Distribution, Wholesale, and Channel Management

Distribution becomes more clearly regulated and more tightly supervised

 RED – HIGH PRIORITY

Licensed Distribution

Drug distribution is more explicitly licensed and tied to premises control and pharmacist responsibility.

Widened Product Scope

The widened product scope means distributors handling non-drug health products may be drawn into a more formal regime.

 Executive implication: distribution becomes a more regulator-exposed function, with **less room for informal channel variation**.

COST IMPLICATIONS

- **Distributor licence remediation**
- **Premises upgrades**
- **Stronger channel oversight and audits**
- **Possible rationalisation of third-party partners**

 Yellow: GDP, record-keeping, and monitoring systems will need uplift across more channel participants. Green: ethical distributors already operate many of these controls, but now under clearer statutory pressure.

Commercial, Marketing, and Portfolio Management

Product claims and portfolio choices become more sensitive

● Red — Portfolio Economics

Expansion of scope means some commercially attractive lines may now carry a **higher regulatory cost** than originally assumed.

❗ Executive implication: portfolio planning needs to reflect compliance overhead, approval timing, and possible market-exit decisions for low-margin lines.

Cost Implications

- Lower profitability on marginal SKUs
- More launch friction
- More internal review effort before claims, campaigns, or channel activity

● Advertising and Promotion Controls

Advertising and promotion controls are broader and more formal, especially for claims and intended use. Requires structured pre-approval review processes.

● Packaging and Labelling

Packaging and labelling changes may require portfolio cleanup across multiple product lines and SKUs.

● Claims Review Discipline

Disciplined claims review is already a standard control in mature businesses – the Bill formalises and extends this expectation.



Pharmacy and Provider-Facing Operations

Embedded pharmacies and dispensing channels face clearer regulatory attention

○ RED — STRUCTURAL REVIEW REQUIRED

Pharmacies in Health Units

Pharmacies in health units and pharmacy operations are more clearly brought into the regulatory regime.

Pharmacist Supervision and Premises Licensing

Pharmacist supervision and premises licensing become more important operating-model issues for provider-linked businesses.

⊗ Executive implication: hospital, clinic, and pharmacy-channel arrangements may need **structural review** to ensure entity, licence, and supervision models are defensible.

COST IMPLICATIONS

- Pharmacist staffing and supervision costs
- Site licensing and inspection readiness
- Restructuring of provider-linked dispensing models where needed

⚠ Yellow: prescription records, restricted-drug controls, and dispensing documentation will remain important in execution.

✅ Green: for well-run pharmacy operations, many underlying disciplines are already normal.

Finance, Procurement, and Planning

The Bill creates cost pressure even where precise numbers are not yet knowable

Red — Real Financial Risk

The widened regime and stronger intervention powers create real risk of **higher recurring compliance spend** and episodic disruption cost.

 Executive implication: the company should expect both implementation cost and a higher steady-state cost of operating regulated portfolios.

COST AREAS LIKELY TO RISE

- **Fees, submissions, and renewals**
- **Regulatory, QA, and safety staffing**
- **Site and system upgrades**
- **Inventory buffers and write-off exposure**
- **Remediation, recall, and crisis-response costs**

 Yellow: more formal certification, records, and monitoring may require systems investment. Green: some spend substitutes for risk that good operators already manage informally.

What the Executive Team Should Do Now

Treat implementation as an enterprise programme, not a legal commentary exercise



Map the Full Portfolio

Map the full portfolio against the Bill's widened scope to identify all product categories now subject to formal regulatory requirements.



Identify Functional Ownership

Identify which functions own each Red exposure, and where accountability is unclear today. Close ownership gaps before they become incidents.



Prioritise Critical Readiness

Prioritise readiness for recall, inspection intervention, lot release, and regulated distribution or pharmacy issues – the highest-consequence areas.



Review Non-Drug Portfolio Uplift

Review whether non-drug portfolios need uplift to pharmaceutical-grade regulatory and quality disciplines under the expanded regime.



Establish Cross-Functional Programme

Establish a cross-functional programme with central reporting to leadership, ensuring coordinated delivery across all affected functions.

Bottom Line

Each function is affected differently, but the leadership response must be coordinated

More Than More Rules

The Bill does not just add more rules. It fundamentally broadens the business areas that fall under hard regulation.

Stronger Authority Powers

It gives the Authority stronger tools to intervene when things go wrong – across the full product and channel landscape.

One Conclusion

Function by function, the Red items point to the same conclusion: stronger enterprise control will be needed across portfolio, quality, supply chain, and channel operations.

The businesses best placed to thrive under this Bill are those that treat regulatory compliance as a **strategic capability** – not a back-office function. The time to build that capability is now.